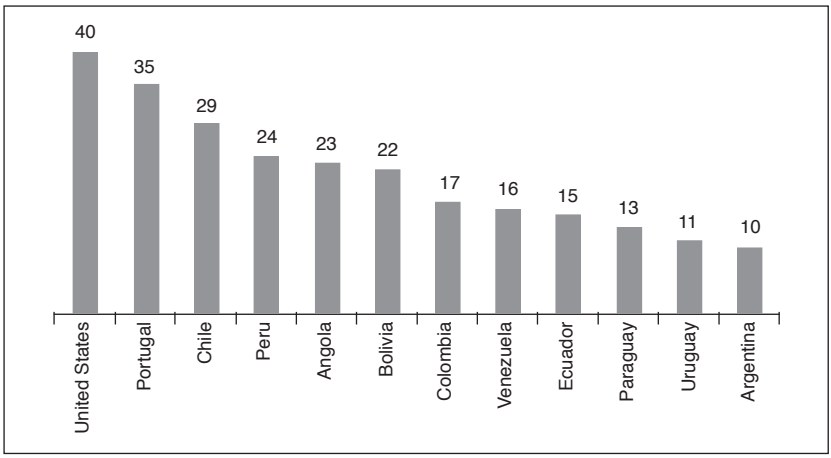
Figure 1. Countries with more than ten contracts with Brazilian contractors



Source: prepared by the author.

in and characteristics of the course of the internationalisation of Brazilian contractors. First, let us analyse the geographical distribution of the contracts.

As Table 1 shows, Brazilian heavy construction companies performed rather vigorously over more than forty years, accounting for 368 contracts in 51 foreign countries in all inhabited continents with the exception of Oceania. In spite of appearing generalised, their activity brings to light a few target countries.

We can see from Figure 1 the countries that were the primary targets of the internationalisation process of Brazilian contractors. It is interesting to note that the American market was the leading target country for Brazilian contractors. This was due to its having the world's largest market for infrastructure projects and its receptivity to other countries' businesses. However, one needs to consider the important presence in this country of Odebrecht, the contractor with a history of success in construction, particularly in Florida and for the American Armed Forces. Odebrecht had 31 of the 40 Brazilian construction contracts in the country.

The Portuguese market, in second place, is also noteworthy. Despite not being a country with a huge volume of infrastructure projects, Portugal's entrance into the European Union, which occurred in 1986, gave rise thereafter to a number of public works interventions in its territory. In this context the Andrade Gutierrez and Odebrecht companies acquired local companies and influence in that market, becoming important agents for the integration of Portuguese infrastructure with European infrastructure. In 1988, Odebrecht absorbed Bento Pedroso